THE FIRST ANTISEMITIC FANFARE: OCTOBER 2005

Israel "must be eliminated from the pages of history. . . . Very soon, this stain of disgrace will be purged from the center of the Islamic world—and this is attainable." This call, delivered by Iranian president Ahmadinejad at a conference in Tehran on 26 October 2005, shocked the world.[27] Israel appealed successfully to the United Nations Security Council for an emergency session. The body met on 28 October 2005 and issued a press statement—the weakest form of expression—but at least condemned the words of the Iranian president.[28]

Many governments, including those of Russia, China, Turkey, Canada, Australia, the Palestinian Authority, and the Vatican, expressed their outrage. The then–twenty-five members of the European Union condemned the Iranian statement "in the strongest terms" while European leaders such as Jacques Chirac and Angela Merkel called it "totally senseless and irresponsible" and "entirely unacceptable."[29]

Nearly all of these statements, however, shared a striking common feature: the systematic avoidance of the word "antisemitism." The only two exceptions among the thirty statements from fifteen countries that I have seen relate to Canada and the United States.[30] "Canada will never accept such hatred, intolerance and anti-Semitism," stated Pierre Pettigrew the then-External Affairs Minister from Canada,[31] while a U.S. Senate resolution of 16 December 2005 condemned "the harmful, destructive, and anti-Semitic statements of Mahmoud Ahmadinejad."[32] All the other comments conspicuously sought to avoid the term antisemitism.

Israel was the only country that wanted more than just a verbal response, arguing for the expulsion of Iran from the United Nations in accordance with Article six of the UN Charter, but to no avail. With the support of his European colleagues, Bernard Bot, the Foreign Minister of the Netherlands, explained "that it was unwise to isolate Iran, adding that there was little enthusiasm in the EU to temporarily suspend Iran's UN membership or recall European ambassadors from Tehran."[33]

In 1989, the European Union nations did indeed withdraw all their ambassadors from Tehran in protest at the death threats against Salman Rushdie. The same happened in 1997 because of the Iranian responsibility for the murder of four Kurds in Berlin's Mykonos restaurant.[34] There was, however, no sign of any similar reaction to Ahmadinejad's calls for the destruction of Israel. Sanctions were also rejected, notably by Germany.[35] As a result, the only concrete action taken was the summoning of Iranian ambassadors in the United Kingdom, France, Germany, Spain, and the Netherlands.[36]

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Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,